UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

District 2 • 2011



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • District 2 • 2011

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The metrical pattern that exhibits a foot consisting of a stressed syllable followed by an unstressed syllable and that is repeated five times per line is

   A) iambic hexameter.
   B) iambic tetrameter.
   C) iambic pentameter.
   D) trochaic pentameter.
   E) trochaic tetrameter.

2. Writing that reads the same from left to right and from right to left is called (a)

   A) boustrophedon.
   B) bouts-rimès.
   C) mesostich.
   D) palindrome.
   E) telestich.

3. The nineteenth-century Scottish author of *The Lay of the Last Minstrel*, *The Lady of the Lake*, *The Heart of Midlothian*, *Waverley*, and *Ivanhoe* is

   A) Robert Burns.
   B) Ewan McTeagle.
   C) Walter Scott.
   D) Adam Smith.
   E) Robert Louis Stevenson.

4. In literature, a term that applies to "all the extravagances of an irregular fancy," including whatever is medieval, natural, primitive, wild, and romantic, is

   A) gazebo.
   B) Gongorism.
   C) gonzoism.
   D) gothic.
   E) grotesque.

5. An anonymous narrative that presents supernatural episodes as a means of interpreting natural events, making concrete and particular a special perception of human beings or a cosmic view, is called a

   A) *chanson de geste*.
   B) epic.
   C) hagiography.
   D) legend.
   E) myth.

6. The French playwright, novelist, and exponent of existentialism who declined the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1964 is

   A) Samuel Beckett.
   B) Albert Camus.
   C) François Mauriac.
   D) Jean-Paul Sartre.
   E) Claude Simon.

7. Not listed among Jane Austen's novel-length works is

   A) *Emma*.
   B) *Mansfield Park*.
   C) *Northanger Abbey*.
   D) *Sense and Sensibility*.
   E) *Wuthering Heights*.

8. A word or phrase made by transposing the letters of another word or phrase, as "cask" is created from "sack," is called a(n)

   A) anacope.
   B) anagram.
   C) anaphone.
   D) raganam.
   E) syncope.

9. The utopian experiment in communal living sponsored by Boston's Transcendental Club during the 1840s is called

   A) Brook Farm.
   B) Comitatus.
   C) Erewhon.
   D) Graustark.
   E) Walden Pond.

10. Either a poem written as though to be sung by a group or a musical composition for unaccompanied male voices, usually a setting of a light or patriotic poem, is called a

    A) ballad.
    B) glee.
    C) madrigal.
    D) masque.
    E) projection verse.

11. The final unraveling, or unknotting, of a plot, the solution of a mystery, or an explanation or outcome of a narrative or drama is the

A) climax.
B) *dénouement*.
C) epiphany.
D) peripety.
E) recalcitrance.

12. The group of twentieth-century writers, especially poets, who struggle to see the world afresh—in a different light—as might a visitor from a distant place, is the

A) Martian School.
B) Parnassians.
C) Saturday Club.
D) School of Night.
E) Symbolists.

13. Not designated by Edmund Burke as one of the four master tropes (master because of their role in the discovery and description of "the truth") is

A) irony.
B) metaphor.
C) metonymy.
D) simile.
E) synecdoche.

14. In literature the concise statement of the ethical or intellectual meaning of any work whose purpose is, in part, to instruct is the

A) aphorism.
B) controlling image.
C) envoy.
D) epigram.
E) moral.

15. The critical approach that began with Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* and with Kate Miller's *Sexual Politics* that has helped make the various national canons more inclusive is

A) feminist criticism.
B) Freudian criticism.
C) queer theory.
D) sociological criticism.
E) textual criticism.

16. The author of *Fire Down Below*, *Rites of Passage*, *Close Quarters*, *The Inheritors*, and *The Lord of the Flies* is

A) Charles Dickens.
B) William Faulkner.
C) William Golding.
D) J. D. Salinger.
E) John Steinbeck.

17. The willingness to withhold questions about truth, accuracy, or probability in a work of literature or in a movie, thus a temporary acceptance of an author's imaginative world, is

A) aesthetic distance.
B) alienation effect.
C) baring the device.
D) objective correlative.
E) suspension of disbelief.

18. The modern movement in politics, economics, and all the arts that, in literature, is characterized by brevity, economy, and modesty, is

A) aestheticism.
B) hermeticism.
C) impressionism.
D) minimalism.
E) surrealism.

19. The Indian-American recipient of the 2000 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for her collection *Interpreter of Maladies* is

A) Ivo Andrić.
B) Irme Kertész.
C) Jhumpha Lahiri.
D) Naguib Mahfouz.
E) Orhan Pamuk.

20. The description of one kind of sensation in terms of another sensation, for example, the description of sounds in terms of colors or the description of sounds in terms of taste, is

A) malapropism.
B) onomatopoeia.
C) perissology.
D) spoonerism
E) synaesthesia.

21. The type of novel in which the characters have a heightened emotional response to events, producing in the reader a similar response, is the

A) novel of character.
B) novel of ideas.
C) novel of incident.
D) novel of manners.
E) novel of sensibility.

22. A term first applied to fifteenth-century Scottish Chaucerians but more accurately referring to the poets of the reign of Henry VIII who introduced the "new poetry" from Italy and France into England is

A) bards.
B) courtly makers.
C) minstrels.
D) poetasters.
E) trouvères.

23. Not associated with the Beat Generation, which was characterized by rebellion against what was conceived of as the failures of mid-twentieth-century American culture, is

A) William Burroughs.
B) Lawrence Ferlinghetti.
C) Allen Ginsberg.
D) Jack Kerouac.
E) J. D. Salinger.

24. The three-line stanza, supposedly devised by Dante, with the rhyme scheme *aba bcb cdc ded* and so forth is called a

A) tercet.
B) *terza rima*.
C) triolet.
D) triple meter.
E) trivium.

25. The American playwright and professor at the University of Houston whose talent has brought him Pulitzer Prizes for his *Seascape*, *Three Tall Women*, and *A Delicate Balance* is

A) Edward Albee.
B) David Auburn.
C) Christopher Durang.
D) Horton Foote.
E) Doug Wright.

26. The principles of versification, particularly as they refer to rhyme, meter, rhythm, and stanza are the focus of

A) metrics.
B) poetics.
C) prosody.
D) reception theory.
E) scansion.

27. Literature, usually prose fiction, entirely or partly written as letters, such as Richardson's *Pamela*, Fielding's *Shamela*, and Goethe's *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, is called

A) comparative literature.
B) didactic literature.
C) epistolary literature.
D) frontier literature.
E) romantic literature.

28. The poet whose writings portray the private, personal matters characteristic of confessional poetry and who was awarded the 1967 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry is

A) Claudia Emerson.
B) Louise Glück.
C) Jorie Graham.
D) Anne Sexton.
E) Natasha Trethewey.

29. A pause or break in a line of verse, which in classical literature occurs near the middle of a line, is

A) caesura.
B) chiasmus.
C) elision.
D) enjambment.
E) hiatus.

30. The British monarch whose reign enjoyed the talents of Thomas Kyd, William Shakespeare, Christopher Marlowe, Edmund Spenser, and Philip Sidney is

A) Elizabeth I.
B) Elizabeth II.
C) Henry VII.
D) Henry VIII.
E) Victoria.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Eugene O'Neill's *The Hairy Ape*.
Items 37-43 are associated with Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*.
Items 44-50 are associated with Theodore Roethke's poetry (selected).

31. In O'Neill's *Hairy Ape* the dreamily poetic contrast to the stokers' immediate surroundings, "Oh, to be scudding south again wid the Power of the Trade Wind driving her on steady through the nights and days!" is spoken by

A) Bob.
B) Long.
C) Mildred.
D) Paddy.
E) the Voice.

32. Throughout his conversing and musing, Yank exalts in the power that he gives to the ship, which he understands in terms of

A) "breath[ing] and swallow[ing] coal dust [. . .]."
B) "feeding our lives along wid the coal."
C) it "plow[ing] throu all de tripe [. . .]."
D) "twenty-five knots a hour."
E) "a waste product in the Bessemer process."

33. The majority of the settings in *The Hairy Ape* draw attention to one of the play's major themes,

A) dehumanization.
B) disassociation.
C) disrespect.
D) naturalism.
E) zoomorphism.

34. Senator Queen's disparaging reworking of the Wobblies' official name, which serves to motivate Yank, is

A) Industrial Whackers of the World.
B) Industrial Women of the World.
C) Industrial Workers of the World.
D) Industrial Wreckage of the World.
E) Industrious Wreckers of the World.

35. The aunt is unrelenting in her criticism, advising Mildred at one point to be as "artificial" as she usually is; her criticism is followed by accusations of

A) "Bloody Cow!"
B) "Faker!"
C) "Poser!"
D) "Puddler!"
E) "Slummer!"

36. "Yer been actin' and talkin' 's if it was all a bleedin' personal matter between yer and that bloody cow. I wants to convince yer she was on'y a representative of her clarss. I wants to awaken yer bloody clarss consciousness" begins Yank's lesson from

A) the Dutchman.
B) the Guard.
C) Long.
D) Paddy.
E) the Second Engineer.

37. In Austen's *Pride and Prejudice* the quick retort, "I have a high respect for your nerves. They are my old friends," defines the relationship between

A) Mrs. Annesley and Georgiana Darcy.
B) Mr. Bennet and Mrs. Bennet.
C) Mr. Darcy and Elizabeth.
D) Elizabeth and Lady Catherine.
E) Mr. Wickham and Mr. Collins.

38. The declaration "[E]very impulse of feeling should be guided by reason" best characterizes

A) Elizabeth.
B) Jane.
C) Kitty.
D) Lydia.
E) Mary.

39. Hunsford Parsonage, for which Mr. Collins seeks a mistress, is located near

A) Longbourn.
B) Meryton.
C) Pemberley.
D) Rosings Park.
E) Westerham.

40. Austen's characters are given to uttering remarks not unlike "Indeed he has no improper pride," which is a fine example of

A) ambiguity.
B) hyperbole.
C) litotes.
D) oxymoron.
E) paradox.

41. The narrator, in carefully summing up the emotional response of one particular character, notes a readiness to blame "every body but the person to whose ill judging indulgence the errors of her daughter must be principally owing"; the character is

A) Mrs. Bennet.
B) Lady Catherine.
C) Lady Darcy.
D) Mrs. Gardiner.
E) Lady Lucas.

42. "[I]f she is really headstrong and foolish, I know not whether she would be a very desirable wife to a man in my state, who naturally looks for happiness in the marriage state"; this characteristically candid statement is made by

A) Mr. Bennet.
B) Mr. Bingley.
C) Mr. Collins.
D) Mr. Darcy.
E) Mr. Wickham.

43. The thematic importance of the novel's title might be best recognized in the questioning statement, "What did you say of me, that I did not deserve? For, though your accusations were ill-founded, formed on mistaken premises, my behaviour to you at the time, had merited the severest reproof," delivered by

A) Mr. Bennet to Mr. Darcy.
B) Lady Catherine to Mr. Collins.
C) Darcy to Elizabeth.
D) Elizabeth to Darcy.
E) George Wickham to Lydia Bennet.

Items 44-46 refer to Theodore Roethke's

My Papa's Waltz

The whiskey on your breath
Could make a small boy dizzy;
But I hung on like death:
Such waltzing was not easy.

We romped until the pans
Slid from the kitchen shelf;
My mother's countenance
Could not unfrown itself.

The hand that held my wrist
Was battered on one knuckle;
At every step you missed
My right ear scraped a buckle.

You beat time on my head
With a palm caked hard by dirt,
Then waltzed me off to bed
Still clinging to your shirt.

44. The meter that characterizes Theodore Roethke's "My Papa's Waltz" is suggestive of

A) abuse.
B) dance.
C) life.
D) pain.
E) song.

45. The tone of the poem, especially as it is driven by diction, as well as rhyme and rhythm, is arguably

A) ambiguous.
B) facetious.
C) mocking.
D) ominous.
E) sentimental.

46. The poem's rhyme scheme features

A) beginning rhyme.
B) compound rhyme.
C) eye rhyme.
D) feminine rhyme.
E) identical rhyme.

Items 47-50 refer to Theodore Roethke's

The Pure Fury

1

Stupor of knowledge lacking inwardness—
What book, O learned man, will set me right?
Once I read nothing through a fearful night,
For every meaning had grown meaningless.
Morning, I saw the world with second sight,
As if all things had died, and rose again.
I touched the stones, and they had my own skin.

2

The pure admire the pure, and live alone;
I love a woman with an empty face.
Parmenides put Nothingness in place;
She tries to think, and it flies loose again.
How slow the changes of a golden mean:
Great Boehme rooted all in Yes and No;
At times my darling squeaks in pure Plato.

3

How terrible the need for solitude:
That appetite for life so ravenous
A man's a beast prowling in his own house,
A beast with fangs, and out for his own blood
Until he finds the thing he almost was
When the pure fury first raged in his head
And trees came closer with a denser shade.

4

Dream of a woman, and a dream of death:
The light air takes my being's breath away;
I look on white, and it turns into gray—
When will that creature give me back my breath?
I live near the abyss. I hope to stay
Until my eyes look at a brighter sun
As the thick shade of the long night comes on.

47. The tone of the second stanza of Roethke's poem "The Pure Fury" as it regards the woman is

A) compassionate.
B) condemning.
C) condescending.
D) contemplative.
E) contemptuous.

48. The declared need for solitude and the need to share in the living of life implicit in the phrase "That appetite for life" (lines 15-16) create the poem's central

A) image.
B) paradox.
C) symbol.
D) tragedy.
E) volta.

49. The persona argues in the first stanza that reading and studying should be replaced with an empirical approach to life characterized by

A) dying and rising.
B) finding meaning.
C) sleeping and waking.
D) sleeping without a book.
E) touching and seeing.

50. The last line of the poem features (a)

A) metaphor.
B) onomatopoeia.
C) paradox.
D) rhopalic.
E) simile.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-55 refer to Oscar Wilde's

Impression du Matin*

The Thames nocturne of blue and gold
Changed to a Harmony in grey:
A barge with ochre-coloured hay
Dropt from the wharf: and chill and cold

The yellow fog came creeping down
The bridges, till the houses' walls
Seemed changed to shadows and St. Paul's
Loomed like a bubble o'er the town.

Then suddenly arose the clang
Of waking life; the streets were stirred
With country waggons: and a bird
Flew to the glistening roofs and sang.

But one pale woman all alone,
The daylight kissing her wan hair,
Loitered beneath the gas lamps' flare,
With lips of flame and heart of stone.

*impression of the morning

51. Oscar Wilde's word choice that both announces and emphasizes the multi-level shift in the lyric poem "Impression du Matin" occurs in line 9 and is a fine example of

A) dissonance.
B) onomatopoeia.
C) pun.
D) synaesthesia.
E) wrenched accent.

52. While most of the senses are captivated by Wilde's description of a London morning, the pervasive imagery remains

A) auditory.
B) gustatory.
C) olfactory.
D) tactile.
E) visual.

53. The poem's basic metrical pattern is

A) iambic pentameter.
B) iambic tetrameter.
C) spondaic pentameter.
D) trochaic pentameter.
E) trochaic tetrameter.

54. The continuation of the sense and grammatical construction from the first stanza to the second stanza is called (a)

A) boustrophedon.
B) enjambment.
C) fused rhyme.
D) run-on line.
E) tag-line.

55. The first stanza presents color patterns in terms of sound: *nocturne* and *harmony*; the describing of one kind of sensation in terms of another is called

A) chiaroscuro.
B) montage.
C) mosaic.
D) reversal.
E) synaesthesia.

Items 56-60 refer to Keith Douglas's

Vergissmeinnicht*

Three weeks gone and the combatants gone
returning over the nightmare ground
we found the place again, and found
the soldier sprawling in the sun. 4

The frowning barrel of his gun
overshadowing. As we came on
that day, he hit my tank with one
like the entry of a demon. 8

Look. Here in the gunpit spoil
the dishonoured picture of his girl
who has put: *Steffi*. *Vergissmeinnicht*.*
in a copybook gothic script. 12

We see him almost with content,
abased, and seeming to have paid
and mocked at by his own equipment
that's hard and good when he's decayed. 16

But she would weep to see today
how on his skin the swart flies move;
the dust upon the paper eye
and the burst stomach like a cave. 20

For here the lover and killer are mingled
who had one body and one heart.
And death who had the soldier singled
has done the lover mortal hurt. 24

* forget me not

56. Douglas's attributing emotion to the mechanized extension of the human capacity to hate in line 5 of "*Vergissmeinnicht*" is an example of

A) barbarism.
B) bombast.
C) metonymy.
D) personification.
E) reification.

57. Following the example of many of the World War I poets, Douglas emphasizes the disruption of normalcy with his use of

A) consonance.
B) eye rhyme.
C) feminine rhyme.
D) *rime retournée*.
E) *rime riche*.

58. The lines "For here the lover and the killer are mingled / who had one body and one heart" (21-22) comprise a profound

A) climax.
B) doppelgänger.
C) locus classicus.
D) paradox.
E) tautology.

59. The stanza, which in its grammatical disconnect, offers a sense of the persona's having to deal with conflicting emotions is

A) stanza five.
B) stanza four.
C) stanza six.
D) stanza three.
E) stanza two.

60. Ultimately, the title anticipates the

A) emotions of the girlfriend, Steffi.
B) German soldier's death.
C) persona's reaction to the corpse.
D) persona's reaction to the picture.
E) persona's willingness to kill.

Items 61-65 refer to Robert Frost's

Acquainted with the Night

I have been one acquainted with the night.
I have walked out in rain—and back in rain.
I have outwalked the furthest city light.

I have looked down the saddest city lane.
I have passed by the watchman on his beat
And dropped my eyes, unwilling to explain.

I have stood still and stopped the sound of feet
When far away an interrupted cry
Came over houses from another street,

But not to call me back or say good-bye;
And further still at an unearthly height
One luminary clock against the sky

Proclaimed the time was neither wrong nor right.
I have been one acquainted with the night.

61. The poetic form of Robert Frost's "Acquainted with the Night" is the

A) caudate sonnet.
B) English sonnet.
C) Italian sonnet.
D) *rime couée*.
E) *terza rima*.

62. The tone of Frost's poem is

A) comically optimistic.
B) gravely melancholy.
C) ironically earnest.
D) morbidly remorseful.
E) musingly nostalgic.

63. The type of repetition appearing at the beginning of the first five lines of the poem is called

A) anaphora.
B) epistrophe.
C) pleonasm.
D) polyptoton.
E) symploce.

64. The persona's very personal acquaintance with the night is, no doubt, metaphorical; death serves as the metaphor's vehicle, and the persona's having endured great difficulty is the metaphor's

A) image.
B) motif.
C) tenor.
D) theme.
E) virgule.

65. The persona's response to the "watchman on his beat" suggests his

A) guilt.
B) loneliness.
C) not wishing the rain to hit his face.
D) reluctance to share his existential burden.
E) uncertainty about the curfew.

The required Tie-Breaking Essay prompt is found on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three pages of blank paper have been provided for this essay; however, it is not expected that the essay will be longer than 150 words; however, the essay should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than a few sentences.

Read Emily Dickinson's "[A narrow fellow in the grass]" and Theodore Roethke's "Snake," and offer a discussion of the personas' appreciation of the natural world as it manifests itself in their separate reactions to the snake.

[A narrow fellow in the grass]

A narrow fellow in the grass
Occasionally rides;
You may have met him,—did you not,
His notice sudden is.

The grass divides as with a comb,
A spotted shaft is seen;
And then it closes at your feet
And opens further on.

He likes a boggy acre,
A floor too cool for corn.
Yet when a child, and barefoot,
I more than once, at morn,

Have passed, I thought, a whip-lash
Unbraiding in the sun,—
When, stooping to secure it,
It wrinkled, and was gone.

Several of nature's people
I know, and they know me;
I feel for them a transport
Of cordiality;

But never met this fellow,
Attended or alone,
Without a tighter breathing,
And zero at the bone.

Emily Dickinson

Snake

I saw a young snake glide
Out of the mottled shade
And hang, limp on a stone:
A thin mouth, and a tongue
Stayed, in the still air.

It turned; it drew away;
Its shadow bent in half;
It quickened and was gone.

I felt my slow blood warm.
I longed to be that thing.
The pure, sensuous form.

And I may be, some time.

Theodore Roethke

2nd _____ _____

1st _____ _____
score initials

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest

ANSWER SHEET

Contestant # _____ Conference # _____

Please write answers as CAPITAL letters.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. _____	11. _____	21. _____
2. _____	12. _____	22. _____
3. _____	13. _____	23. _____
4. _____	14. _____	24. _____
5. _____	15. _____	25. _____
6. _____	16. _____	26. _____
7. _____	17. _____	27. _____
8. _____	18. _____	28. _____
9. _____	19. _____	29. _____
10. _____	20. _____	30. _____

number correct _____ x 1 pt each = _____

Part 2: UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

31. _____	38. _____	45. _____
32. _____	39. _____	46. _____
33. _____	40. _____	47. _____
34. _____	41. _____	48. _____
35. _____	42. _____	49. _____
36. _____	43. _____	50. _____
37. _____	44. _____	

number correct _____ x 2 pts each = _____

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism **15 items (2 points each)**

51. _____	56. _____	61. _____
52. _____	57. _____	62. _____
53. _____	58. _____	63. _____
54. _____	59. _____	64. _____
55. _____	60. _____	65. _____

number correct _____ x 2 pts each = _____

total points

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest
District 2 • 2011
KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 11e, the Penguin 1996 edition of *P&P*, and the Vintage edition of *The Hairy Ape*.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History — **30 items (1 point each)**

1.	D		11.	B	156	21.	E	377
2.	D	394	12.	A	332	22.	B	131
3.	C		13.	D	239	23.	E	698
4.	D	253	14.	E	354	24.	B	548
5.	E	358	15.	A	226	25.	A	665
6.	D	658	16.	C		26.	C	443
7.	E		17.	E	537	27.	C	205
8.	B	24	18.	D	346	28.	D	663
9.	A	78	19.	C	661	29.	A	81
10.	B	251	20.	E	541	30.	A	

Part 2: UIL Reading List — **20 items (2 points each)**

31.	D	148	38.	E	33	45.	A	
32.	D	153	39.	D	86	46.	D	226
33.	A		40.	C	317	47.	C	
34.	E	185	41.	A	273	48.	B	398
35.	C	159	42.	C	108	49.	E	
36.	C	175	43.	C	347	50.	A	341
37.	B	7	44.	B				

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism — **15 items (2 points each)**

51.	B	384	56.	D	412	61.	E	548
52.	E		57.	A	123	62.	B	
53.	B		58.	D	398	63.	A	26
54.	B	199	59.	B		64.	C	547
55.	E	541	60.	C		65.	D	

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Dickinson's "[A narrow fellow in the grass]" and Roethke's "Snake"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

contrast,
couplet,
diction,
free verse,
imagery,
metaphor,
meter,
onomatopoeia,
optimism,
personification,
simile,
style,
sympathy/empathy,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to discuss the appreciation of the natural world that is evident in each of the persona's reactions to meeting a snake on his own turf. The discussion might well be a comparison, though it might focus solely on contrasting elements, especially style and tone. He or she might find the quality of the language, which is visual (and suggestive of auditory) in Dickinson's present-tense encounter and characteristically sensuous in Roethke's memory of the encounter, a point of focus.

Both Dickinson and Roethke find pleasure in observing a snake; however, Dickinson spends a bit more time with the snake itself; Roethke moves quickly toward the possibility of identifying himself in terms of the snake.

The young writer might point to the distance established and maintained in the Dickinson observation, a distance that is empathetically closed in the Roethke observation-become-identification.